

Posner 2004 RG Notes

Posner, Daniel N.. “The Political Salience of Cultural Difference: Why Chewas and Tumbukas Are Allies in Zambia and Adversaries in Malawi” [2004].

American Political Science Review 98(4): 529-545.

When do cultural cleavages become politically salient? See Lipset & Rokkan (1967) who introduce three such conditions: empirical framework, normative element, and organizational framework

Claims that the salience of cultural cleavages can be largely determined by contextual factors *external to* the cleavages themselves: namely, whether or not the resultant groups formed from those cleavages are effective vehicles for political mobilization

Single biggest factor is size: are the resulting groups large enough such that they can be meaningful political groups?

Natural experiment with Chewa and Tumbuka tribes in Zambia/Malawi: cleavage becomes politically salient/antagonistic in Malawi, but not so in Zambia – much more of an alliance. Conducted surveys within villages straddling the Malawi/Zambian border to evaluate the differential political impacts of those cleavages across the border.

Potentially interesting note here – using colonial borders as a framework for a natural experiment, since they were drawn administratively rather than culturally and are therefore largely random